followed by the shah's return. All of this took place around the same time as the Nasser revolutions in Egypt, the many military coups in Syria, and finally the coup d'état in Iraq in 1958. The shah began the second chapter of his reign concerned about the possible consequences of these revolutions, and with a hatred and fear of the Arabs. This is certainly one of the explanations as to why the shah sought intelligence, military, and economic cooperation with Israel. Moreover, Iran found itself in a dilemma: it had been a powerful empire but was currently weak, and it was looking for a way to restore its former glory. It knew that in order to fulfill this ambition it had to emulate the West, certainly in terms of technological advancement.

A further insight: throughout Iran's history, there has been a constant tension between religion—the religion of Shiism—and secularism. In modern times, during the years of the shah's reign, secularism and modernity ruled the roost. However, the shah was able to maintain a controlled "exhaust pipe" that allowed believers to express their faith in the public sphere, especially during Ashura, the days of remembrance of the prophets Ali and Hussein, central figures in the Shiite religion. On these memorial days, huge processions of believers would walk through the streets dressed in black, flagellating themselves with chains and cutting themselves with knives to the point of streaming blood, while reading verses from the Koran that put the marchers into a state of uncontrolled ecstasy. Each year, ahead of Ashura, the government would use the various media in order to warn foreigners in the country about the expected events and would recommend that they remain in their homes and refrain from going out to public places. I, living there as a local, was able to experience these horrifying rituals firsthand.

The "White Revolution" in the early 1960s was a formative event in the history of Iran. This revolution, initiated by the shah, turned the country's peasant farmers from serfs and vassals into independent landowners. This change affected the status of the country's feudalists, among whom were many clerics, which exacerbated the relationship between the secular shah and the ayatollahs, the religious leaders. The reform was made possible only after the dissolution of the Majlis, the Iranian parliament, which enabled the passage of the land reform law.

Muhammad Reza Pahlavi, the dynasty's last shah, succeeded his father Reza Shah, who was exiled to South Africa in 1941. It took him some twenty years to stabilize the kingdom. During World War II, Iran was